

Expert Q&A;: Will My Children Inherit My Arthritis?

Genetics, risk and what really raises a child's odds.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Review Board** (Multidisciplinary UK clinicians) · 2026-06-25 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Overview



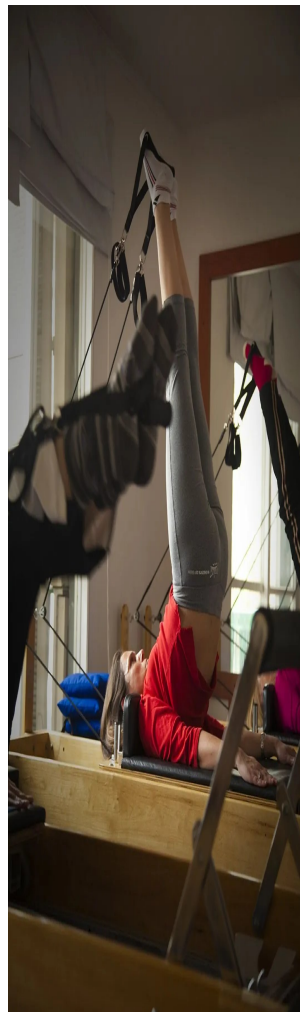
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Genetics, risk and what really raises a child's odds.

What the evidence shows

UK guidance from NICE, the British Society for Rheumatology and Versus Arthritis consistently emphasises a combined approach: appropriate medication, regular movement, and supportive lifestyle changes. Recent reviews continue to back this consensus.

What this means for you



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- **Talk to your clinician.** Personalised advice always beats blanket rules.
- **Track your symptoms.** Use a simple diary so you can spot patterns over weeks, not days.
- **Move within comfort.** Gentle, regular activity protects joints and mood.

- ****Watch the warning signs.**** New swelling, fever, or rapid loss of function deserve same-week review.
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Practical next steps

1. Read our companion piece for a deeper dive: [\[related guidance\]](#)[\(/conditions/rheumatoid-arthritis\)](#).
 2. Bring three questions to your next GP or rheumatology appointment.
 3. Share this article with a family member who supports you day to day.
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Editorial standards



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This article was prepared by the Living With Arthritis Editorial Team and reviewed by our Clinical Review Board against UK NICE guidance and peer-reviewed sources. We update content at least annually.

What the Evidence Says

Current understanding from systematic reviews and clinical guidelines points to a complex picture when it comes to the inheritance of arthritis. While certain types of arthritis, like rheumatoid arthritis and psoriatic arthritis, have a genetic component, it's rarely a simple case of direct inheritance. Instead, what children inherit is a predisposition or increased susceptibility.

This means that while genes might load the gun, environmental factors often pull the trigger. Large population studies have helped identify specific genes linked to a higher risk, but these genes are common in the general population, and most people with them will never develop arthritis. This highlights that lifestyle, infections, and other external factors play a crucial role.

The evidence consistently shows that having a close relative with certain types of arthritis increases a child's risk factor, but this risk is still relatively small in most cases. It's more about a combination of many genes working together, alongside those environmental triggers, rather than a single 'arthritis gene' being passed down.

Common Mistakes to Avoid

* **Assuming destiny:** Believing your child will definitely get arthritis because you have it – most children of people with arthritis do not develop the condition. * **Ignoring early signs:** Dismissing joint pain or swelling in children as "growing pains" – consult a professional for new or persistent symptoms. * **Over-restricting activity:** Preventing children from playing sports or being active due to fear of joint damage – tailored physical activity is crucial for joint health. * **Self-diagnosing:** Using internet searches to diagnose your child's symptoms – always seek expert medical opinion. * **Focusing solely on genetics:** Overlooking the important role of healthy lifestyle choices in managing risk – encourage a balanced diet and regular exercise.

When to Speak to a Clinician

If you have concerns about your child's risk of developing arthritis, or if they are showing any new or persistent symptoms, it's always best to have a chat with a doctor. Early diagnosis and

intervention can make a significant difference.

* Persistent joint pain or stiffness, especially in the morning. * Swelling, warmth, or redness in one or more joints that doesn't go away. * Unexplained limping or difficulty with everyday movements. * Ongoing fatigue that impacts daily activities. * Fever alongside joint symptoms without an obvious cause like an infection.

Frequently Asked Questions

Can my child be tested for arthritis genes? While genetic tests exist for some conditions, routine genetic screening for arthritis risk in children isn't usually recommended. The presence of specific genes only indicates a higher susceptibility, not a certainty of developing arthritis, and many other factors are involved.

What lifestyle changes can help reduce my child's risk? Encouraging a healthy, balanced diet, regular physical activity tailored to their age, maintaining a healthy weight, and avoiding smoking (especially secondhand smoke) can all contribute to overall health and may help reduce the risk of inflammatory conditions.

If my child develops arthritis, will it be the same type as mine? Not necessarily. While there's an increased risk, it's not guaranteed to be the exact same type of arthritis. Different forms of arthritis have varying genetic predispositions and environmental triggers.

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about expert q&a;: will my children inherit my arthritis??

Short answer: Children do not usually inherit arthritis in a simple, direct way. Some types, including rheumatoid and psoriatic arthritis, have a genetic component, so a close relative can slightly raise susceptibility, but most children will not develop it. Genes interact with triggers such as lifestyle, infections and environment. Seek medical advice for persistent joint symptoms.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Versus Arthritis: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.

General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis UK · livingwitharthritis.org.uk